



Victoria Falls

An immense African waterfall with a unique geological history, plunging into a deep, narrow chasm

Part of the mighty Zambezi River, Victoria Falls crosses the border between Zimbabwe and Zambia in southern Africa. Challenged only by South America's Iguacu Falls (see pp.110–11) for the title of Earth's largest waterfall, it spans more than 5,600 ft (1,700 m) and reaches a height of 354 ft (108 m)—twice that of Niagara Falls (see p.52). It is often described as having the largest sheet of falling water in the world.

Unique formation

The Zambezi runs across a basalt plateau that has large cracks, roughly perpendicular to the river's flow, filled with softer sandstone. Over the

last 100,000 years, the river has eroded the sandstone to leave a series of narrow gorges, the latest of which the river plunges over (see panel, below). The zig-zagging of the gorges, which traces the falls' movement upstream, is due to a series of joints running across the ends of the gorges that have "captured" the river and changed its direction. The narrow chasm formation of the falls produces a spray that can be seen 30 miles (50 km) away.



◁ **FEARSOME PREDATOR**
The Nile crocodile, the largest crocodile species in Africa, is the most fearsome predator found along the Zambezi.

The falls' local name, **Mosi-oa-Tunya**, translates as "**the smoke that thunders**"



◁ **ON THE EDGE**
The falls form part of two national parks, both with large populations of elephants. Occasionally, one will venture out onto the falls to feed on trees on the islands.

△ **FALLING IN SECTIONS**
The islands in the river on the edge of the falls separate the flow into several recognized sections (from left): the Devil's Cataract, Main Falls, Rainbow Falls, and the Eastern Cataract.

THE VICTORIA FALLS GORGES

The steep, narrow gorges below Victoria Falls mark their changing positions over time. The Devil's Cataract, on the far west side, is the point at which a new waterfall is in the early stages of cutting back.

